

THE FIVE, AS PEOPLE

Fable, v1.1, 2026-08-29. Revision pass. Still written blind: Fable has not been told who did it.

Nell Casey

Nell Casey was forty-four and painted letters for a living. Shop fronts, boat names, the menu boards outside the harbour cafés, and once, for a bet, the side of a bus. She had a unit behind the fish market with a kettle, a radio that only got one station, and a ladder she would not let anyone else climb. On the morning she died the old Regent cinema had three of its six letters back, and the ladder was still chained to the railing under them.

She swam off the slip most mornings from April to November and said it was for her back. It was for the quiet. She ate standing up, fried egg on white, and kept her cash in a Quality Street tin because she distrusted the bank and, more than that, invoicing. She was owed money all over town and forgot nobody who owed it. She read the last page of a book first. She smoked two cigarettes a day behind the unit and lied about it with total confidence. She had one brush she had made herself, sable on a handle cut from a broken oar, green electrical tape at the ferrule, and you could pick it out of a bucket from across the road.

She was funny in a way that cost you something: she ranked people's handwriting out loud and told you the truth about your kitchen. She was halfway through a thing with the council about parking, a thing with her sister about their mother's house, and a thing with the cinema owner about the colour of the R. None of it is finished. That is how you know she was there.

Owen Pask

Owen Pask, forty-six, runs the crane at the boatyard and has known Nell since they were eleven and shared a school bus. He is the only one who met her mother, and so the only one who knew Nell before she was good at anything: loud, badly dressed, in trouble. He drove her to the hospital the night her mother went in for the last time, and neither of them ever mentioned it. He swims off the slip because she did and hates it. On a Tuesday he came to the unit at half twelve, ate whatever she was eating, and said nothing for twenty minutes. She called it his visit. He owns a third of the yard, bought quietly eight years ago, and lets the town think he is staff. He has a real tenor voice and uses it only in the crane cab with the door shut.

Frightened, Owen gets tidy. He cleans tools that are already clean. He writes lists and loses them. He runs a thumb along the edge of a table before he sits at it. He goes very reasonable, which is worse than shouting, because you can hear him deciding what not to say.

He thinks Margo is sound, if cold, and would trust her with paper. He thinks Bram is a kid Nell collected, and that she would have got bored of him. He has never liked Sian; her kindness, he thinks, is a way of being in charge. It has a date: the second of August 2014, Nell's kitchen, a bottle, and a question about her mother's house that one of them asked and the other answered. Nell laughed. They have never agreed at which of them.

Sian Reddy

Sian Reddy, thirty-nine, is the practice nurse at the surgery on Wharf Street and joined the slip swimmers nine years ago because a patient said it helped. Nell told her she swam like someone being chased. They were

friends by August. On a Tuesday Sian texted at six to say she wasn't coming, then came, and they sat in the car with the heater on arguing about whether Sian's husband should be told a thing. Sian is the one Nell rang at four in the morning, once, three years ago. Sian drove over. They never talked about what was said, and when Sian tried, Nell changed the subject so fast it was like a door closing. Sian has not had a drink in six years. She holds a tonic and lets them assume gin, and it has never come up. She had grade eight piano at fourteen and lets the surgery think the Christmas carols are the extent of it.

Frightened, Sian talks. She fills the room, allocates jobs, makes tea nobody asked for. She ends her own sentences with "anyway", as if handing them over. Underneath it she is counting exits. She reads bodies for a living, can tell a lie from the neck, and has stopped trusting that since Nell died: she stood in that kitchen a hundred times and saw nothing.

She loves Bram without quite respecting him. She finds Margo hard work and honest. She has never liked Owen. She thinks his silence is a performance, and that Nell fell for it for thirty years.

Margo Lisk

Margo Lisk, fifty-three, does the accounts for half the harbour and did Nell's for free, which Nell resented. They met when Nell lettered the office door and undercharged, and Margo posted a cheque for the difference with a note that said "don't be a martyr". That was fourteen years ago. Margo does not swim. She stands on the slip with a flask. The three think she can't; she swam for the county at fifteen and has never corrected them. On a Tuesday she left a bag of receipts on the counter at the unit and on Friday collected it unopened, a joke neither of them found funny any more. Every second Sunday she drives two hours up the coast to a woman called Hen. Eleven years. None of the three has heard the name. Margo is the one who knew about the money. Nell had more than anyone would guess, and not from painting letters, and Margo knows where from. She has told nobody and does not intend to.

Frightened, Margo gets sharp. She says the true thing in the worst way. She has made Sian cry twice since the funeral and apologised once. She is eleven minutes early to everything and waits in the car for the hour. She sleeps badly and does sums at three in the morning that come out the same every time.

She rates Owen. She finds Sian exhausting and right about most things. She has never liked Bram. She thinks he was Nell's project, and that projects end.

Bram Tolley

Bram Tolley, thirty-four, is a signwriter, his own van, his own customers, some of them once hers. He turned up at the unit seven years ago, a design teacher then, asking Nell to teach him. She refused, then did it anyway, Tuesday evenings, for money at first and then for nothing. Here a second signwriter is one thing to the first: she sent him the jobs she did not want, boat names in a hurry, the pub that changed its name every spring, and he said thank you. When she was behind she sent him up the ladder she would not let anyone climb. He swims badly and only in summer and she never let him hear the end of it. He is the only one she talked to about the other three, and has told nobody what she said: it would make him look like what Margo says he is. He has a boy of nine two towns over, alternate weekends, and has never said the word son in front of them. He ran a marathon under three hours in spring and told them it was a wedding.

Frightened, Bram jokes. Then he drinks. Then he goes still in a way that is not calm, and if you speak to him then he will answer a question you didn't ask. He puts his keys on the table when he sits and moves them

twice.

He likes Margo, which she does not believe. He thinks Sian is the best of them and the easiest to lie to. He has never known what to do with Owen, who reads him the way a man reads the bottom of an invoice, and he has stopped trying.

Least sure of: Bram's boy. A child is the one hidden thing that cannot stay a texture note; if it is used at all it will pull the whole passage toward it, and if it is not used it is a loose wire.